Raleigh Chapter

Buffalo Soldiers Motorcycle Club

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The National Association of Buffalo Soldiers and Troopers Motorcycle Club was growing. An idea started by one man in Chicago with a passion for riding and a vision for what a Motorcycle Club (MC) should be was catching on. It was a clean image. Clean both in terms of the well-earned reputation from the community it served and clean in the way it's members presented themselves. They had eye catching "cuts" that drew attention. Once they had your attention they presented an MC that had a purpose larger than itself. Yes, the Buffalo Soldiers Motorcycle Club (BSMC) was about riding; but it was also about doing good community service and above all paying respect to the men (and Cathay Williams) of 9th and 10th US Calvary. They honor a piece of American history. When riding a club member is a "solider" which is a constant reminder that you not only represent the club you also represent and pay tribute to something much larger. As a primarily black MC there was a natural affinity to honor the black regiments who in 1866 came into being carrying the burden of war and the burden of a fight against racism, bigotry, intolerance and ignorance. They confronted both.

The MC aligned itself with those Buffalo Soldiers regiments, and specifically the 9th and 10th Calvary, formed after the end of the civil war. Along with the all-black Calvary there was also the all-black 24th and 25th Infantry. But, there are those that walk and those that ride. We ride.

It was back in 1993 when that man's vision became a reality and the first MC was formed. When more "Buffalo Soldiers" clubs starting forming both in Chicago and in other cities and states an effort was made to unify the MCs and in 1999 the National Association of Buffalo Soldiers and Troopers Motorcycle Club was born.

The explosion in growth came to North Carolina in June of 2001 when the Fayetteville chapter was formed. Fayetteville began with 14 members and has grown to close to 50 today.

In 2009, four of those Fayetteville chapter members decided to form a new chapter closer to their homes and to serve their local community. Sydalg "SuperSyd" Severe, Cornell "Cobra" Chandler, Curtis "Stampede" Porter and Dwain "Joker" Brown set out to form a chapter in Raleigh.

The path to Raleigh wasn't direct. Because of a previous incident with someone attempting to start a Raleigh chapter one member successfully blocked the chapter's formation in Raleigh claiming the location was within the 100 mile limit in place at that time. To get past the roadblock the new chapter was instead formed in Louisburg in April 2009 (which is why our club elections are held in April).

After the formation, Syd became the first club President, Cobra Vice President, Stampede as Secretary and Joker was Treasurer. Early probies coming to the club included Ralph "Matador" McNeil and Price "No Problem" Barden (who shortly afterwards would become club chaplain and retains that honor today).

After a year on probation the club was charted on May 1st 2010. Three years later in August of 2013 the club officially moved location to Raleigh. Appeals were made to the State Council, to the Southeast Frontier and ultimately to National where the move to Raleigh was granted (and the 100 miles exclusion limit was reduced to 50 miles).

A change in officers came when Syd moved out of state to Michigan. Cobra became the 2nd club President while Stampede and Joker kept their offices as Secretary and Treasurer. The next change of leadership came when Hondo became the 3rd President in 2013 however he did not serve his full 2 year term. Matador finished the remainder of Hondo's term and then was elected twice to serve as the 4th President. In 2019 Christopher "Dealmaker" Robinson won election as the 5th President and in April of 2021, Donald "Chief" Mial was elected as 6th club President. Like Hondo, Chief did not serve his full term. Escalations to National and Frontier over allegations of misuse of the authority of office led to an inquiry and review by representatives from Frontier on November 2, 2021 that culminated with the removal from office of the President. In addition the Vice President, Secretary and Sergeant at Arms were also removed from office. Officer replacements were named. A month later the chapter unanimously voted in the replacement officers. With that Darryl "Professor Q" Lester became President. Fred "Bruh Fred" Nielson became Vice President. Theo "6 Hundred" Wilkins became Secretary. Bryant "Apache" Green became Sergeant at Arms. Patricia "Queen" Robinson retained her position, without change, as Treasurer. Those are the current officers as of this date.

During the club's 12 year history it has grown from the original four members to about 35 today. In the early days, the club was small but they did a lot of riding and a lot of community service. As a small group they were tight knit. Today the club still has a focus on riding and community service. Although the COVID-19 pandemic clearly limited both in 2020. As is natural with group dynamics, as the number of members grew so did the number of viewpoints and opinions. And like a family, squabbles are inevitable. But so is the overwhelming strength and conviction in the brotherhood and sisterhood of the Buffalo Soldiers.

Key Moments in Raleigh Chapter History

At a National Convention in those early years the Raleigh chapter was recognized with a best small chapter award. The chapter was out performing a lot of community volunteer work at church events, schools, senior's events like bingo, distributing food at Thanksgiving and Christmas, and Marine toy drop-off. They took advantage of getting out in the public and showing their colors on club rides and biker events like the Ray Price Harley Bikefests. As a result they were recognized at the National level for those efforts and making a difference in the community.

In keeping with the vision established during the inception of the Buffalo Soldiers MC, the Raleigh chapter embraced the inclusion of woman. Today there are seven women in the chapter. Patricia "Queen Bee" Robinson, one of the first women full patch members, became the first woman to serve on the Executive Board and currently holds the office of Treasurer.

While not a Raleigh specific initiative, moments drawn from large Buffalo Soldiers group gatherings provide an opportunity for the club to represent itself and in doing that, in part, define itself. National and Frontier meetings provide those opportunities and allow the club to establish its identity among other chapters.

Other defining moments are opportunities taken to provide education on the Buffalo Soldiers 9th and 10th Calvary to the Triangle community. Emphasis on reaching out through schools, churches, museums and other opportunities helped establish the reputation of the Buffalo Soldiers Raleigh chapter in the community as well as help present and preserve a key part of history. Moments of community sharing like the Friends and Family day of 2018 and adopting families for Christmas to provide gifts for children help shape the image of the Raleigh Chapter and provide gratifying moments for chapter members.

Proud of the Raleigh Chapter

When a sampling of Raleigh chapter members were asked what they were most proud of as a Raleigh chapter member almost universally the reply included the clubs

brotherhood and sisterhood. Critical to the identity of the club is the caring each member shows to others who share the Raleigh patch. As more than one person put it it's not that there aren't differences internally. But those come up in a specific context of a topic and are internal only. In the end we all wear the same patch and to the external community we are one club. The word "family" is often used.

Community service is another key part of the Raleigh club identity and a point of pride. Community service, along with providing a helping hand to those in need, is an excellent way to show the community what the club is about and represent a positive image. That leads to community respect for the club and promotes community interest in partnering or joining.

The chapter has embraced the contributions of its members, including the associate members. The associate member perspective might best be articulated by Kim "3rd1" Barden as she speaks with great passion for the pride she has for being a Buffalo Soldier and the impact she sees in people in the communities served by the chapters many civics activities. All this while alongside her husband and the other soldiers she thinks of as family.

Also mentioned is the desire to embrace diversity. Diversity in people and ideas. It's hard to know where the next significant contribution to the club (or by the club) will come from and embracing all people and their perspectives helps uncover new ideas.

As one member summed it up: "Show compassion and love. Show it to the community and it will be contagious."

Thank You…

Thanks to the following members for their contributions and review.

- Dwain "Joker" Brown
- Price "No Problem" Barden
- Ralph "Matador" McNeil
- Kim "3rd1" Barden
- Chris "Dealmaker" Robinson
- Theo "6-Hundred" Wilkins